

# HousingChoice — Product Framework & Scope

*A plain-language overview of what the product does and how it works. Written so a non-technical reader can follow it completely.*

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## 1. The product in one paragraph

HousingChoice is a **tenant placement engine for Section 8 housing**. We connect housing-voucher holders with rental units they will actually be approved for, and we guide them through the entire move — all over **text message**, the way our customers already communicate. Landlords pay us a fee when a tenant successfully moves in. Today this runs largely by hand. This document describes the **software product** that turns that hands-on process into a repeatable, scalable engine — while keeping every conversation feeling human.

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## 2. Who it's for

HousingChoice sits in the middle of three groups and solves a problem for each:

- **Tenants (voucher holders)**. Often single parents, seniors, or people working in-person jobs. They're overwhelmed by the search, don't know where they'll actually be approved, and live on text — not apps or listing websites.
- **Landlords**. They want their units filled with reliable Section 8 tenants without wrestling with HUD paperwork and an endless stream of calls and follow-ups.
- **Housing authorities**. They're overworked and need their voucher holders placed before the vouchers expire.

We serve all three at once. Tenants get a home they qualify for; landlords get a filled unit with the process handled; authorities get vouchers used instead of lost.

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## 3. What the product does (the core promise)

1. **Brings the right units to the tenant** — instead of a listing site they have to sift through, we deliver a short list of options directly to them.

2. **Shows only units they're likely to be approved for** — we don't waste anyone's time on places that will reject them.
3. **Handles the whole journey** — sharing units, tours, applications, and the 30–45 day Section 8 approval process.
4. **Communicates entirely by text**, blending a smart AI assistant with our human team so it always feels personal.

A useful proof point from how this already works by hand: properties that have sat empty for three months on listing sites get filled in about ten days once HousingChoice is involved.

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## 4. Guiding principles (the non-negotiables)

These rules shape every design decision. They matter as much as the features.

- **Conversational, never a bot.** No "press 1 for this, press 2 for that" menus. Every message reads like it came from a real, thoughtful person.
  - **Text-first.** Our customers communicate by text. The product meets them there.
  - **Human-in-the-loop.** The AI assists and speeds things up, but people stay in control. The AI knows when to step back and hand a conversation to a teammate.
  - **Best-fit and likely-approved only.** Quality of match over quantity of listings.
  - **Warm, plain, respectful tone.** Our customers are stressed and under deadline pressure. The product's job is to reduce that stress, never add to it.
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## 5. How it works — the tenant's journey, start to finish

This is the heart of the product. Everything below happens through natural text conversation; the technology works quietly in the background.

1. **First contact.** A tenant texts our business number. Through a natural back-and-forth, we learn who they are and what they need — bedroom size on their voucher, the areas they want, how they get around (for example, needing to be near transit), whether they need to avoid stairs, pets, household size, their move timeline, and — importantly — when their voucher expires.
2. **Matching (behind the scenes).** The system quietly finds the few units that both fit what the tenant needs and that this tenant is likely to be approved for. The tenant doesn't see any of this machinery — they just get good options.

3. **Sharing units.** The assistant texts a small number of options with photos and asks, in plain language, what they think — never a numbered menu, just a real question like "Do any of these feel right? Anything off about them?"
4. **Feedback and refining.** The tenant replies in their own words ("the second one's too far from my kids' school, and I need a ground floor"). The system understands that, updates what it knows about them, and shares better options. This share → react → refine loop continues like a normal conversation.
5. **Touring.** Once a tenant is interested, we arrange and confirm the tour and send reminders.
6. **Applying.** We send the application, make sure it gets completed, and collect what's needed.
7. **Section 8 approval (the 30–45 day stretch).** This is the long, detail-heavy part. The system tracks each step, keeps the tenant and the landlord updated, flags anything stuck, and watches deadlines — especially the voucher expiration.
8. **Move-in and placement fee.** When the tenant successfully moves in, the landlord is billed the placement fee.

At **any point** in this journey, a human teammate can step into the conversation, and the assistant will step back.

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## 6. How the AI and the team work together (the most important section)

This is what makes HousingChoice different from a chatbot, and it's the principle the whole product is built around.

**The assistant is a teammate, not a robot.** It reads each conversation the way our best placement specialist would, and on every incoming message it does one of three things: replies naturally, writes a suggested reply for a person to approve, or stays quiet and taps a human in.

**Every conversation has a setting that controls the AI:**

- **Auto** — the assistant replies on its own, but only for safe, routine messages.
- **Draft** — the assistant writes a suggested reply, and a teammate approves or edits it before it sends. (A good default while we build trust.)

- **Manual** — the assistant stays silent; a person handles the whole conversation.
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## 7. The matching engine (your expertise, turned into software)

Today, the founder does this matching in her head. The product's job is to write those instincts down as rules the software can run thousands of times.

In plain terms, the engine answers two questions for every tenant and unit:

1. **Does this unit fit what the tenant needs?** Bedroom size matches the voucher, rent is within what the voucher will cover, the location and commute work, stairs/accessibility needs are met, pets are allowed.
2. **Will this landlord approve this tenant?** Each landlord has their own rules — income requirements (remembering the voucher itself counts as income), how they treat past evictions, utility debt, credit, and references. The engine compares the tenant against *that specific landlord's* criteria.

The output is the handful of units the tenant fits **and** is most likely to be approved for, ranked best-first. This codified knowledge is the company's core advantage — it's what no listing site has.

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## 8. The main parts of the product

Think of these as the rooms in the house:

- **Conversation hub** — the shared text inbox where the AI and the team work side by side.
  - **Tenant profiles** — who each tenant is and what they need.
  - **Units & landlords** — every available unit and each landlord's specific approval criteria.
  - **The matching engine** — described above.
  - **The pipeline dashboard** — a simple view of where every tenant stands (new → matched → touring → applied → in approval → placed).
  - **Reminders & alerts** — automatic nudges for stalled steps and voucher expirations.
  - **Team dashboard** — where the team monitors everything and steps in when needed.
  - **Later additions** — landlords onboarding themselves by uploading documents, recertification support, and housing-authority contracts.
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## 9. What the system remembers (the data, in plain terms)

The product keeps four kinds of information: **tenants** (who they are and what they want), **units and landlords** (what's available and each landlord's rules), **every message** (so any teammate can pick up a conversation with full context), and **the status of every match** (where each one is in the journey). Because much of this is sensitive personal information, it is stored securely with access limited to the right people.

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## 10. The building blocks (technology, explained simply)

You don't need to be technical to understand the pieces:

- **The phone line — Quo (Need to switch Dialpad)** (a business texting service, formerly OpenPhone). It sends and receives the texts and, importantly, lets our software plug into those messages.
- **The conversation brain — Claude** (the AI). It reads conversations, writes natural replies, understands tenant feedback, and decides when to hand off to a person.
- **The workflow/automation layer.** The connective tissue that ties the texts, the AI, and the database together and enforces the "send, draft, or stay quiet" decision.
- **The database.** Where everything is stored.
- **The team dashboard.** Where the team does its work.

**Where we are today (the MVP):** a working first version stitched together from Quo (the phone line), an automation tool called n8n, Claude front end dashboard, and Airtable (used as the database). It proves the concept and is already handling real tenant conversations.

**Where we're going (the new product):** the same ideas on a sturdier foundation — one that can handle higher volume, more team members, and additional markets without breaking. This document is the blueprint for that build.

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## 11. What we build first, and what comes later

- **Phase 1 — the core loop.** Tenant intake by conversation, the matching engine, sharing units and handling feedback, the shared conversation hub with AI/human handoff, and the pipeline board.
- **Phase 2 — depth.** Full Section 8 approval tracking with reminders, and letting landlords onboard themselves by uploading documents.

- **Phase 3 — scale.** Multiple markets, the Atlanta Housing Authority contract workflow, and recertification support for tenants already housed.
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## 12. Who uses it, and what they can do

- **Founder / admin** — full access to everything, including billing and landlord criteria.
  - **Support team (VA's)** — handle conversations, tours, and applications day to day, with access scoped to what they need.
  - **The AI assistant** — drafts and sends messages only within the limits set for each conversation.
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## 13. Trust, safety, and compliance (must-haves, not nice-to-haves)

- **Fair housing.** The assistant is built to avoid anything that could violate fair-housing rules, and any sensitive topic is routed to a person.
  - **Texting consent and registration.** Tenants opt in to be texted, and the business texting is properly registered with carriers (a requirement called A2P 10DLC) so messages reliably reach people instead of being blocked.
  - **Privacy.** Tenant information is sensitive. It's stored securely, and access is limited to the people who need it.
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## 14. How we'll know it's working

- Placements per month (the number that drives revenue).
  - Time from a tenant's first text to move-in.
  - How many shared units turn into tours, applications, and placements.
  - Vouchers saved — placed before they expire.
  - Team capacity — how many placements each team member can carry, which is what proves the engine is scaling the founder out of the day-to-day.
  - Tenant sentiment — are people calmer and better served than before.
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## 15. Glossary

- **Section 8 / Housing Choice Voucher** — a federal rental-assistance program; the voucher covers a large share of a qualifying tenant's rent.

- **Voucher holder** — a tenant approved for that assistance who is looking for a home.
  - **Payment standard** — the maximum rent the voucher will cover in a given area; a unit's rent has to fit within it.
  - **Placement** — a tenant successfully moving into a unit through HousingChoice.
  - **Placement fee** — what a landlord pays HousingChoice for a successful placement; equal to one month's rent (about \$956 on average across the U.S.; closer to \$2,000 in Atlanta).
  - **Housing authority** — the local agency that administers vouchers.
  - **A2P 10DLC** — the carrier registration a business must complete to text customers reliably in the U.S.
  - **Quo** — the business phone/texting service (formerly OpenPhone) that carries our texts.
  - **n8n** — the automation tool used in the current version to connect the pieces.
  - **Claude** — the AI that powers the conversations.
  - **Airtable** — the spreadsheet-style database used in the current version.
  - **MMS** — a text message that can include a photo (how we send unit pictures).
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